

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	Hard

Question



A sociology student is reading an essay on the median age of first marriage in Western countries throughout the twentieth century. The author of the essay cites factors common to these countries that the author believes caused an increase in the median age of first marriage, such as new technologies that shortened the time needed for domestic chores, making two-person households less necessary and living alone more viable. The student asserts that beyond these factors there must be additional ones specific to particular Western countries that influenced the increase of age at first marriage.

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph that support the student's assertion?

Answer

- A. Between 1970 and 2000, the median age of first marriage rose more sharply for men in England and Wales than it did for men in the United States.
- B. The median age of first marriage for men in England and Wales was lower in 1970 than in 1950 or 1990.
- C. Between 1900 and 2000, the median age of first marriage for women in England and Wales was consistently higher than for women in the United States, as was the case for men.

D. In England and Wales, the median age of first marriage was consistently higher for men than for women between 1900 and 2000, but this was not always the case in the United States.

Correct Answer: A

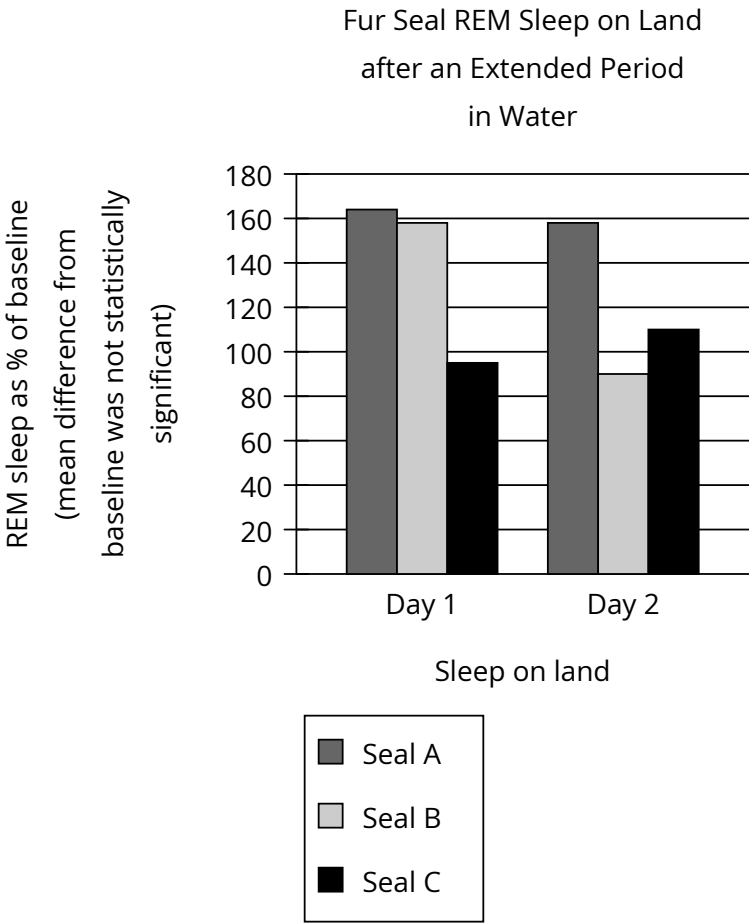
Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The student concluded that country-specific factors influence changes to median age of first marriage. This choice describes a time period when the rate of change differed between countries, suggesting that country-specific factors may have played a role in these changes.

Choice B is incorrect. The student concluded that country-specific factors influence changes to median age of first marriage. However, this choice doesn't provide any contrasts between countries and thus doesn't support the idea of country-specific factors influencing median age of first marriage. Choice C is incorrect. The students' conclusion is about changes that occurred during the 20th century. This choice provides broad information about the century as a whole, so it doesn't give insight into how median age at first marriage changed over time. Choice D is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. The median age of first marriage was consistently higher for men than for women in the United States during the time period depicted.

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SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	Hard

Question



Research suggests that REM sleep in animals is homeostatically regulated: animals compensate for periods of REM sleep deprivation by increasing subsequent REM sleep. When on land, fur seals get enough REM sleep, but during the weeks they’re in the water, they get almost none. In a study of fur seals’ sleep habits, researchers recorded the REM sleep (as a percentage of baseline) of fur seals once they had returned to land. They concluded that REM sleep may not be homeostatically regulated in fur seals, citing as evidence the fact that the seals in the study

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the text?

- Answer
- A. didn’t consistently demonstrate a significant increase in REM sleep after their period of deprivation in the water.
 - B. showed no significant difference between REM sleep after returning to land and REM sleep while in the water.
 - C. didn’t show significantly less REM sleep during the second day after returning to land than they did during the first day.
 - D. showed no significant differences from one another in baseline levels of REM sleep.

Correct Answer: A

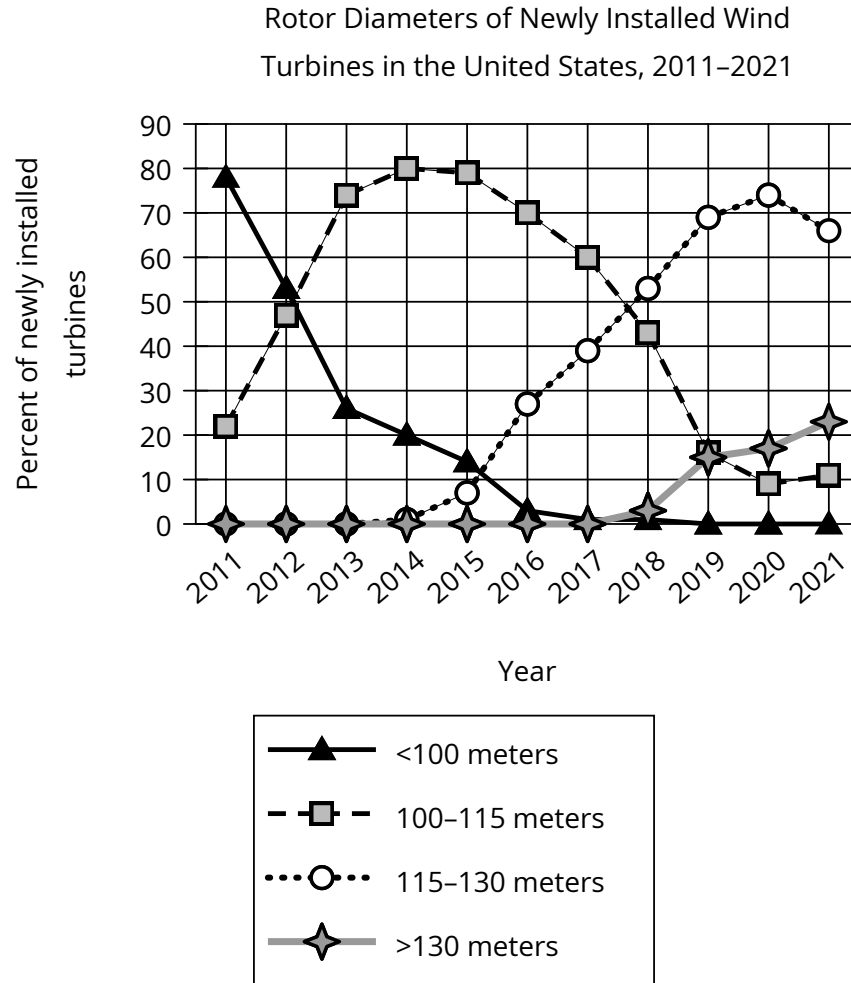
Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. If REM sleep were homeostatically regulated in fur seals, then all the seals would compensate with REM levels significantly over baseline after going weeks without REM. We'd also expect the seals to maintain those elevated REM levels for some time. Since seals B and C return very quickly to baseline REM levels, this suggests that REM sleep in fur seals may not be regulated homeostatically.

Choice B is incorrect. The graph doesn't depict REM sleep while in the water for the seals in the study. Additionally, we're told fur seals get no REM sleep while in the water, which is significantly different to the values shown in the graph for after they return to land. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn't support the conclusion. If REM sleep were homeostatically regulated in fur seals, then we'd suspect the seals to sustain REM levels well above baseline for a prolonged period in order to compensate for weeks of REM deprivation while in the water. Whether or not there's a reduction in REM sleep from day 1 to day 2 doesn't tell us how REM sleep on those days relates to baseline, which is where our focus should be. Choice D is incorrect. The y-axis of this graph doesn't depict baseline levels of REM sleep, but rather shows REM sleep as a percent of baseline.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	Medium

Question



All other things being equal, the larger a wind turbine's rotor diameter (the diameter of the imaginary circle swept by the turbine's rotating blades), the greater amount of energy the turbine can generate. In a research paper on wind power, a student claims that in the United States, the amount of energy generated per newly installed turbine increased substantially between 2011 and 2021.

Which choice best describes data in the graph that support the student's claim?

Answer

- A. No turbines installed in 2011 had rotor diameters greater than 115 meters, whereas the majority of turbines installed in 2021 had rotor diameters greater than 130 meters.
- B. Most turbines installed in 2011 had rotor diameters of less than 100 meters, whereas most turbines installed in 2021 had rotor diameters of at least 115 meters.
- C. In 2011, nearly 80% of turbines installed had rotor diameters of less than 100 meters, whereas only a little more than 20% of turbines installed that year had rotor diameters of 100–115 meters.
- D. The percentage of newly installed turbines with rotor diameters greater than 130 meters increased every year between 2011 and 2021.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text tells us that turbines with larger rotor diameters produce more energy, so if rotor diameters have generally gotten larger between 2011 and 2021, then turbines created in 2021 should produce more energy than those created in 2011.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. In 2021, only about 25% of turbines installed in 2021 had rotor diameters greater than 130 meters. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn't justify the claim. The claim is about increasing energy output from 2011 to 2021, but this choice only discusses 2011, so it can't show evidence of change over time. Choice D is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. The percentage of newly installed turbines with rotor diameters greater than 130 meters didn't show any visible increase until 2018.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	Hard

Question

Declining fishing technology costs and overexploitation of near-shore fishing grounds have made isolated oceanic reefs, which often lack regulatory protections, increasingly attractive to commercial and sport fishers. A team led by Octavio Aburto-Oropeza surveyed the biomass density and species composition of two isolated reefs: Alacranes, a protected (fishing prohibited) reef 135 kilometers from the Yucatan Peninsula, and Bajos del Norte, an unprotected reef 25 kilometers farther out to sea. Species at the highest level of the trophic pyramid constituted 34% of the biomass at Alacranes and 10% of the biomass at Bajos del Norte. Aburto-Oropeza and colleagues attribute this difference to the two reefs’ difference in regulatory status.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Aburto-Oropeza and colleagues’ explanation?

Answer

- A. Total biomass at Alacranes is much greater than total biomass at Bajos del Norte, though the reefs’ biomass densities are similar.
- B. Some of the species that compose the highest trophic level at Bajos del Norte are not found at Alacranes.
- C. It is somewhat more expensive for commercial and sport fishers to reach Bajos del Norte than it is to reach Alacranes.
- D. Commercial and sport fishers tend to disproportionately remove species at the highest trophic level.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it provides the finding that, if true, would most directly support Aburto-Oropeza and colleagues’ explanation that species composition differs between Alacranes and Bajos del Norte because of a difference in the regulation of fishing at the two reefs. The text explains that isolated oceanic reefs are often unprotected and are increasingly attracting commercial and sport fishing activity. According to the text, when Aburto-Oropeza and colleagues surveyed Alacranes, an isolated reef where fishing is prohibited, and Bajos del Norte, an isolated reef that is unprotected, they found that species at the highest trophic level (that is, top predators) make up a smaller proportion of the total mass of all living organisms at Bajos del Norte (10%) than they do at Alacranes (34%). If it were true that commercial and sport fishers tend to disproportionately remove top predators—that is, that they catch them at a higher rate than they catch other species—this would support the explanation that the allowance of fishing at Bajos del Norte and the prohibition of fishing at Alacranes has led to a lower proportion of top predator species remaining in the total biomass at Bajos del Norte.

Choice A is incorrect. To support the researchers’ claim that the role of fishing regulations accounts for Alacranes having a greater proportion of species at the highest trophic level (top predators) than Bajos del Norte does, a finding would need to help explain how fishing affects the presence of top predator species in particular; the finding that the two reefs have similar biomass densities (that is, about the same mass of living organisms per unit) and that Alacranes has a much greater total biomass (total mass of living organisms) wouldn’t reveal anything about the species composition at each reef or help explain why the *proportion* of top predators in the total biomass at each reef differs. This finding might simply suggest that Alacranes is a larger reef, with more units at that density. Choice B is incorrect because the finding that there are species at the highest trophic level (top predators) at Bajos del Norte that aren’t found at Alacranes would reveal only that there are some different species in the reefs’ total biomasses (total mass of living organisms) but wouldn’t explain why that’s the case; this finding wouldn’t be clearly connected to the role of fishing regulations, which is what, according to the researchers, accounts for the reefs having different proportions of top predators in their total masses. Choice C is incorrect. To support the researchers’ claim that the role of fishing regulations accounts for Alacranes having a greater proportion of species at the highest trophic level (top predators) than Bajos del Norte does, a finding would need to help explain how fishing affects the presence of top predator species in particular, but different costs of reaching the two reefs wouldn’t affect fishing behavior at all because fishing isn’t even allowed on one of the reefs.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	Hard

Question

The Polynesian languages, a group of related languages originating on islands in the Pacific, typically have _____ array of consonant sounds. For example, the Mangareva language of the South Pacific has nine consonants, and ‘Ōlelo Hawai‘i, the language of the Native Hawaiian people, has eight. Globally, however, the median number of consonants per language is over twenty-two.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

Answer

- A. an unvarying
- B. a musical
- C. an exclusive
- D. a modest

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Polynesian languages. In this context, “modest” means relatively limited or small. The text begins with a statement about the array, or number, of consonant sounds in these languages. It then gives examples of one Polynesian language that has nine consonants and one that has eight consonants before noting that the global median number of consonants per language is more than twenty-two; in other words, the numbers of consonants in the Polynesian examples are well below the global median number. This context conveys that the text is making the point that the Polynesian languages have a modest array of consonant sounds.

Choice A is incorrect. In this context, “unvarying” would mean unchanging. The text focuses on comparing the typical numbers of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages to the global median number of consonants per language, not on conveying that the number of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages typically doesn’t vary; the text makes no mention of the number of consonants changing within a language or language group. Choice B is incorrect because the text is focused on the quantity of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages, not the idea that those consonants are “musical,” or pleasantly harmonious and like music; the text discusses only the numbers of consonants in Polynesian languages and the global median number of consonants per language, not the way consonants sound. Choice C is incorrect. In this context, “exclusive” would mean limited to a single group. The text discusses the typical numbers of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages and gives two examples of languages with consonant numbers below the global median number of consonants per language, but it doesn’t suggest that the array, or number, of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages is exclusive to those languages—that is, that Polynesian languages are the only ones with eight to nine consonants.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	Medium

Question

Yanzhe Fu et al. suggest that the extinct aquatic insect *Karataviella popovi* utilized a brood care strategy that mitigated the risk of oxygen deficiency. This determination rests on the researchers’ analysis of fossils uncovered at a particularly _____ site: China’s Haifanggou Formation, which has yielded a vast diversity of fossils, including those of long-proboscid scorpionflies.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

Answer

- A. fruitful
- B. unassailable
- C. obscure
- D. quantified

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the fossil site from which the evidence about brood care in *K. popovi* was recovered. In this context, “fruitful” means abundantly productive. The text indicates that the researchers drew their evidence from fossils found in China’s Haifanggou Formation, a location that has yielded a vast diversity of fossils. The information about the site yielding a vast diversity of fossils supports the characterization of the Haifanggou Formation as particularly productive, or fruitful.

Choice B is incorrect because there is nothing in the text to support characterizing the Haifanggou Formation as a site that is particularly “unassailable,” or not open to attack, question, or criticism. The text emphasizes that the site has yielded a vast diversity of fossils, suggesting that it is a particularly productive location for fossil hunters, not that it cannot be challenged. Choice C is incorrect because there is nothing in the text to support characterizing the Haifanggou Formation as a site that is particularly “obscure,” or poorly understood or relatively unknown. In fact, the text notes that the Haifanggou Formation has yielded a vast diversity of fossils, suggesting that the site is not an obscure one. Choice D is incorrect because “quantified” means expressed or measured as a quantity, which does not describe the productiveness the context calls for. Although the text indicates that the Haifanggou Formation has yielded a vast diversity of fossils, that fact suggests that the site can be characterized as particularly productive, not as particularly quantified.

Question ID: 1e274153

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

During World War II, codebreakers played an essential role in deciphering coded messages. In the US military, more than 10,000 women _____ as codebreakers, making up nearly half of all US codebreakers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. having served
- B. to serve
- C. served
- D. serving

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite (tensed) verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, “more than 10,000 women”), and this choice supplies the finite past tense verb “served” to state what the women did.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “having served” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive “to serve” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “serving” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Question ID: 6174a5b6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Many folktales that originate in the Czech language start with a phrase that roughly translates to “there was, there was not.” Many tales that originate in English use “once upon a time.” Such phrases, known as story starters, _____ from language to language.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. vary
- B. has varied
- C. varies
- D. is varying

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb “vary” agrees in number with the plural subject “such phrases.” The supplementary phrase “known as story starters,” set off by commas, doesn’t change the subject’s number.

Choice B is incorrect. The singular verb phrase “has varied” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “such phrases.” Choice C is incorrect. The singular verb “varies” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “such phrases.” Choice D is incorrect. The singular verb phrase “is varying” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “such phrases.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

For the past 20 million years, Earth’s magnetic poles in the far north and far south have remained roughly where they are today. This has not always been the _____ throughout geologic history, Earth’s magnetic poles have swapped places several times through a process called polar wandering.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. case, though
- B. case, though,
- C. case; though,
- D. case, though;

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. Placing the semicolon after the supplementary adverb “though” correctly indicates that the contrast in the text is between the information in the first sentence (that Earth’s magnetic poles have remained fixed for the past 20 million years) and the initial clause of the second sentence (“This has not always been the case”), rather than between the two clauses of the second sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Using the adverb “though” as the head of a subordinate clause illogically indicates that the information in the previous main clause (“This...case”) is contrary to the information in the subordinate clause. Instead, the information in the second clause (that Earth’s magnetic poles have swapped places several times) elaborates on the statement made in the previous clause (that Earth’s magnetic poles are not as fixed as they may seem). Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can’t be used in this way to punctuate a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect. Using a semicolon after “case” places the adverb “though” inside the second main clause (“throughout...wandering”), illogically indicating that the information in the previous main clause is contrary to the information in the second one. Instead, the information in the second main clause (that Earth’s magnetic poles have swapped places several times) elaborates on the statement made in the previous clause (that Earth’s magnetic poles are not as fixed as they may seem).

Question ID: a421f749

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In Puerto Rico, it’s not unusual for a city or town to be known by a nickname that corresponds to one of its notable features, like landscape, climate, famous residents, or chief export. For example, the Puerto Rican municipality of Aibonito is well known for its lush _____ this distinction has earned it the fitting nickname of “the Garden of Puerto Rico.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. greenery
- B. greenery,
- C. greenery and
- D. greenery;

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between two main clauses. “Aibonito is well known for its lush greenery” and “this distinction has earned it the fitting nickname...” are both complete main clauses; a semicolon correctly joins them while signaling a close logical connection.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect. When coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction.